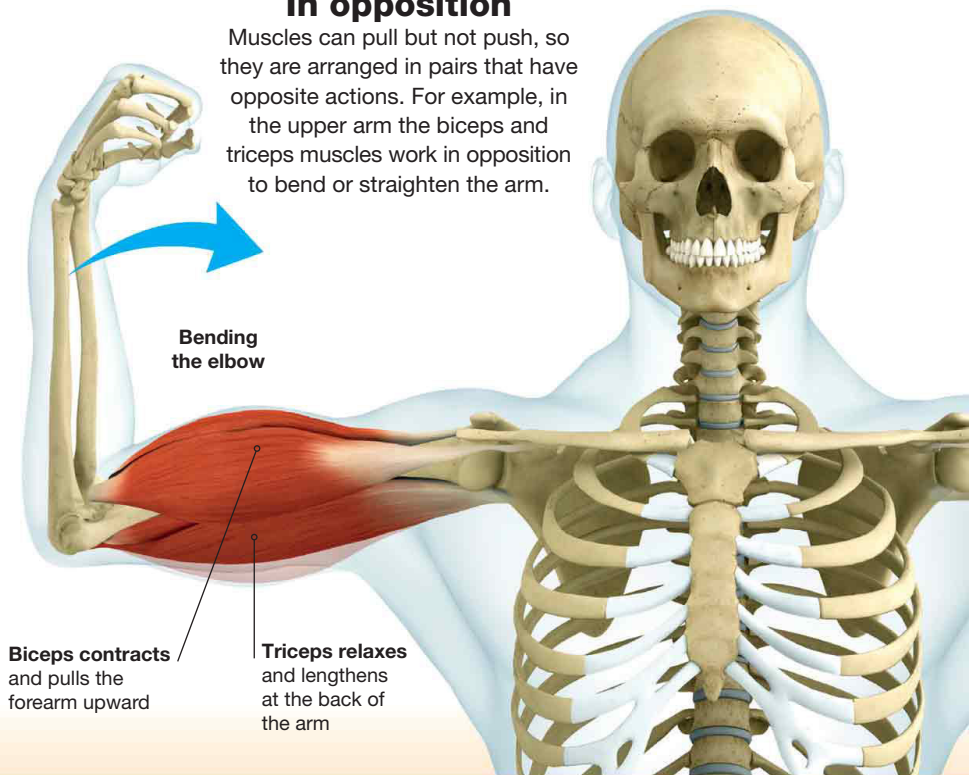


How muscles work

When skeletal muscles get instructions from the brain, they use energy to contract (shorten) and pull bones. Once the movement is complete, they relax and lengthen. Facial muscles tug at the skin of the face to produce different expressions.

In opposition

Muscles can pull but not push, so they are arranged in pairs that have opposite actions. For example, in the upper arm the biceps and triceps muscles work in opposition to bend or straighten the arm.



**Bending
the elbow**

Biceps contracts
and pulls the
forearm upward

Triceps relaxes
and lengthens
at the back of
the arm